

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

**T**his is the small town on Kerala's northern edge and is known for its three Cs. Cakes, for some of its finest bakeries, circus since this place used to provide more than 90 per cent of the artistes for the now-dying industry and cricket, because this is where Colin Cowdrey, one of the most successful captains in English cricket, first put bat to ball.

But all these are now history. Over the last few years, Thalasserry, in Kannur district, has been sporadically grabbing the headlines for its crass political violence. At least 200 persons have been killed and thousands maimed over the last 30 years in tit-for-tat violence between BJP-RSS and CPI(M), both of which have deep roots in these areas. While the casualties may seem small, they are rather steep for a state not known for the blood and gore variety of politics. The latest round of violence in the first week of March claimed seven lives in three days. Five

**POLITICS OF BLOOD: RSS workers marching for a clash with CPI(M) (right); body of a killed RSS man**



SHANKAR

# OLD BATTLE NEW GROUND

**With the attack on CPI(M)'s national headquarters, the RSS-Marxist revenge killings are all set to cross the state border**

of the victims belonged to BJP-RSS while two were CPI(M) workers. The killings were belated retaliation for the murder of four CPI(M) workers in Thalasserry and two in Palakkad district between November and January.

Until now, this mutual annihilation between the two long-standing adversaries had seldom crossed the boundaries of Thalasserry, at worst reaching the borders of Kannur district. However, this time the repercussions were felt across the country. As their colleagues fell victims to communists'

wrath in Kerala, BJP-RSS activists stormed the CPI(M)'s national headquarters in AKG Bhavan in Delhi and destroyed furniture and parts of the library. Six senior party members, who came to attend the party's Central Committee meeting were injured and several cars parked outside, including that of Politburo member Sitaram Yechury were damaged. Police had to resort to tear gas shelling to disperse the mob. Subsequently there were attacks at the Bangalore house of V.J.K. Nair, CPI(M) state secretary of

Karnataka, at Sundarayya Vignana Kendram, the CPI(M)'s research institute in Andhra Pradesh and also the party's district committee office in Nagercoil, Tamil Nadu. "Incidents at Delhi and other places were only natural reaction. CPI(M) can no longer think that they can unleash violence against their opponents in their strongholds," says P.K. Krishnadas, state BJP president.

BJP national leaders like L.K. Advani and Venkaiah Naidu called on the Central Government to take note of the CPI(M) atrocities in Kerala and even